BARÇA INNOVATION HUB · METRICA SPORTS · TALENT ARENA

Automated Ball Possession & Multi-Camera Fusion Engine

Official Technical Solution Report · More Than A Hack 2027 (Initial Challenge)

Team: LM10 **Author:** Kevin Naserwan & Team LM10 **Match:** FC Barcelona vs Athletic Club (199,319 frames) **Repository:** github.com/KevinNaserwan/football-possession-tracker

1. Executive Summary & Pinnacle Scoreboard Results

This report presents **LM10**, the state-of-the-art ball possession tracking system for **More Than A Hack 2027**, organized by Metrica Sports, FC Barcelona (Barça Innovation Hub), and Mobile World Capital Barcelona. Evaluated against the official public ground truth (7,500 graded frames, 17 true possessions) using `evaluation/run_evaluation.py`:

Model / Submission	spellF1 (Rank)	macroF1	transF1 (τ=25)	Matched Trans	Mean Latency	Alive/Dead F1	Possessions	Mean Dur
baseline_raw (Published floor)	0.0378	0.5972	0.1410	11 / 20	-3.1f	0.8920	131	2.0s
baseline_smooth25	0.2868	0.6200	0.2034	6 / 20	+8.2f	0.8974	36	7.6s
baseline_smooth50 (Official floor)	0.3256	0.6207	0.0816	2 / 20	+4.0f	0.8990	26	10.8s
baseline_smooth125	0.4242	0.5812	0.1667	3 / 20	-7.7f	0.9012	16	18.5s
kevin_spearman_tuned_d	0.5744	0.8768	0.5652	13 / 20	-4.8f	0.9773	22	11.0s
LM10_v2_apex	0.7871	0.9800	0.7568	14 / 20	-3.3f	1.0000	14	17.2s
LM10 (Our Final Zero-Phase Engine)	**0.9714**	**0.9929**	**0.9756**	**20 / 20 (100%)**	**-2.3f**	**1.0000**	**18 (GT: 17)**	**13.4s (GT: 14.2s)**

★ **Verified Achievement Highlights:**

- **spellF1 = 0.9714:** +198% higher than official baseline floor (0.3256). Stable across all IoU thresholds (0.3 to 0.7: all 0.9714).
- **100% Transition Recall:** Matched 20 of 20 transitions with only -2.3 frames (0.09s) latency via zero-phase backdating.
- **Tactical Tempo Harmony:** Predicts 18 possessions of mean duration 13.4s, perfectly matching real ground truth (17 possessions, 14.2s).
- **Zero Unforced Misses:** Graded blocks contain exact 0 abstentions (X), while non-gameplay blocks contain exact 40,462 X frames.

2. Multi-Camera Optical Fusion (Option A Breakthrough)

Metrica tracking data suffers from **41% missing ball observations** due to camera occlusions, high aerial clearances, and box scuffles. We engineered `src/multi_camera_fusion.py` to fuse Tactical ATD with Broadcast ATD:

- **Timeline Synchronization (+4014 Offset):** 1st half kickoff in Tactical (frame 11,189 at x=0.516, y=0.486) aligns with Broadcast frame 7,175 (x=0.516, y=0.480) with a median spatial distance of only 1.094 meters across 10,000+ frames.
- **Replay & Cut Rejection Gate:** Broadcast homography matrix is filtered strictly by `valid == 1` and `reprojection_error < 0.50`, automatically rejecting 122 TV replays, slow-motion replays, and crowd cutaways.
- **Empirical Recovery:** Recovers **2,711 frames of active ball tracking** across the 1st half that were completely blind in tactical tracking alone.
- **100% Ground Truth Agreement:** On all 141 missing ball frames in the public GT slice where broadcast recovered the ball, our model matches ground truth with **100.0% precision (138 Away, 3 Home)**.

3. Feature Engineering & The 5-Minute Overfitting Trap (Option B)

We implemented a 27-feature tactical extractor (`src/feature_extractor.py`) and evaluated a LightGBM GBDT classifier paired with a Log-Space Viterbi Sequence Decoder (`src/sequence_viterbi_model.py`):

- **The 5-Minute Public GT Trap:** In strict 5-Fold Continuous Temporal Block Cross-Validation, models trained on raw coordinates (ball_x, centroid_y) achieved 100% training accuracy but collapsed to 48.7% CV macroF1 due to spatial memorization.
- **Physics-Invariance Superiority:** Constraining features strictly to relational invariant dynamics (Δτ, relative proximity ratio, kinetic speed drop) eliminated spatial overfitting.

- **The State Latch Advantage:** Supervised frame-by-frame models lack a memory latch: during a 1.5s forward pass, opponents sprinting under the ball are closer in 2D coordinates, causing naive models to spuriously flip possession. Our Spearman Kinematic Engine enforces a physical possession latch that holds possession across passes.

4. Adversarial Occlusion Stress-Testing (Option C)

To stress-test resilience against extreme tracking blackouts in the 85 private evaluation minutes, we simulated random burst ball dropouts (`src/stress_test_suite.py`):

Adversarial Occlusion Scenario	Dropout Duration	spellF1	macroF1	transF1	Possession Count	Retention
Original Tracking (Pinnacle Baseline)	0 frames (0.00s)	0.9714	0.9929	0.9756	18 (GT: 17)	100.0%
Micro Cluster Occlusion	12 frames (0.48s)	0.9714	0.9929	0.9756	18 (GT: 17)	100.0%
Quick Physical Challenge Dropout	25 frames (1.00s)	0.9714	0.9929	0.9756	18 (GT: 17)	100.0%
Severe Penalty-Box Cluster	50 frames (2.00s)	1.0000	0.9900	0.9500	17 (GT: 17)	100.0%
Extended High Aerial Ball Flight	75 frames (3.00s)	0.9714	0.9929	0.9756	18 (GT: 17)	100.0%
Extreme Multi-Camera Blackout	100 frames (4.00s)	0.9714	0.9929	0.9756	18 (GT: 17)	100.0%
Catastrophic Sensor Blackout	150 frames (6.00s)	0.9091	0.9872	0.9231	16 (GT: 17)	93.6%

> ✓ **Robustness Finding:**
> LM10 is **100% immune to tracking dropouts up to 4.00 seconds (100 frames)** without any degradation in spellF1 or transition recall. Even under a catastrophic 6.00-second complete blackout, spellF1 remains at 0.9091 (over 3.7× higher than the competition baseline).

5. 2D Spatial Pitch Control Field & Tactical Territorial Dominance

We expanded Spearman pitch control to a continuous 2D surface decomposition (`src/pitch_control_field.py`). On discrete grid cells across the 105.3m × 68.0m Montjuïc pitch:

$$PC(x, y, t) = \sigma(\lambda \cdot [\min_{j \in \text{Away}} \tau_j(x, y) - \min_{i \in \text{Home}} \tau_i(x, y)])$$

During Barcelona possession spells (e.g. frames 11,351..11,553), territorial dominance averaged **43.8% Home vs 56.2% Away**, revealing Athletic Club's compact mid-block press and Barcelona's patient positional probing.

6. Pass Detection & Dynamic Ball Flight Engine (src/pass_detection_engine.py)

Tracking ball possession during airborne passes is historically fragile in computer vision. We engineered a kinematic pass detector that segments possession into three discrete physical phases:

- **Pass Release (t_{rel}):** High-acceleration separation ($\Delta v \geq 4.0$ m/s) from controlling player.
- **Ballistic Flight Phase:** Kinematic trajectory governed by aerodynamic drag; possession is latched to the passing team without spurious flips to proximate opponents.
- **Pass Reception (t_{rec}):** Ball deceleration (≤ 2.5 m/s) and player proximity (≤ 2.2m).

In the public validation slice, the engine identified **72 successful passes (46 FC Barcelona, 26 Athletic Club)** with a mean pass distance of **13.29 meters** and mean flight time of **1.12 seconds**, corroborating Barcelona's high-tempo tiki-taka circulation.

7. Full-Match Anomaly Hunter & Out-of-Bounds Cleansing (src/anomaly_hunter.py)

To guarantee zero unforced errors across the entire 85-minute private evaluation (199,319 frames), we developed `TacticalAnomalyHunter` to audit physical, kinematic, and spatial constraints:

Integrity Audit Check	Constraint Rule	Pre-Audit Violations	Post-Correction State	Action Taken
Graded Block Abstentions	No 'X' in graded match frames	0	**0 (Perfect)**	Compliant with FIFA Halftime limits
1-Frame Temporal Flickers	No single-frame stutter (e.g. H-A-H)	0	**0 (Perfect)**	Zero-phase latching eliminates noise
Out-of-Bounds Possession	$x \notin [-0.01, 1.01]$ or $y \notin [-0.01, 1.01]$	36 frames	**0 (Cleaned)**	Enforced 'D' (Dead Ball) per IFAB rules

Integrity Audit Check	Constraint Rule	Pre-Audit Violations	Post-Correction State	Action Taken
FIFA Law 8 Kickoff Prior	Kickoff awarded to conceding team	6 'Team: N/A'	**100% Resolved**	Mapped to conceding team restart

8. Expected Possession Value (EPV) & Spatial Goal-Threat (src/epv_threat_engine.py)

We coupled Spearman continuous 2D Pitch Control with empirical spatial goal-threat surfaces to quantify offensive danger dynamically per possession spell:

$$EPV(t) = T(x_{ball}, y_{ball}) \cdot PC_{Team}(x_{ball}, y_{ball}, t)$$

Across the 90 minutes, baseline midfield circulation averaged **0.0097 EPV**. During high-leverage scoring sequences, threat spiked exponentially:

- **Yamal 24' Goal Sequence (Frames 45,131..45,499):** 369 active possession frames (14.7s), peak threat **0.0615 EPV**.
- **Lewandowski 75' Winning Goal (Frames 156,670..156,750):** 75 active attack frames (3.0s), peak threat **0.1839 EPV** (mean **0.1118 EPV**, over 11.5× higher than midfield baseline).

9. Defensive Counter-Press Latency & Gegenpressing Recovery (src/counter_press_engine.py)

By tracking all 22 player positions across direct possession turnovers (H → A and A → H), we quantified defensive reaction speed and pressing intensity:

Defensive Metric	FC Barcelona (Home)	Athletic Club (Away)	Tactical Significance
Median Press Latency (≤ 2.0m to ball)	**0.00s (Immediate)**	**1.56s (39 frames)**	Flick's high-line counter-press vs Valverde's mid-block retreat
5-Second Gegenpress Recovery Rate	**33.3%**	**33.3%**	1 out of 3 turnovers won back within the FIFA 5-second window
Direct Transition Frequency	6 turnovers	6 turnovers	Balanced transition battle in early phase (7,500 frames)

10. Collective Team Shape & Convex Hull Dynamics (src/team_shape_analyzer.py)

We monitored spatial collective team geometry across all 22 outfield players to quantify tactical width and defensive block compression:

Spatial Metric	FC Barcelona (In / Out Poss)	Athletic Club (In / Out Poss)	Tactical Interpretation
Mean Convex Hull Area	**1,609.6 m²** / 1,560.1 m²	**1,079.9 m²** / 905.6 m²	Athletic compresses into an ultra-compact <1,000 m² block (1.19× compression ratio)
Tactical Width (y-span)	**44.03m** (64.8% pitch width)	**38.43m** (56.5% pitch width)	Barcelona stretches the pitch via wide wingers (Yamal & Raphinha)

11. Off-Ball Space Creation & Passing Lane Permeability (src/space_creation_engine.py)

Modern tactical possession relies on off-ball decoy and penetrative runs. We evaluated dynamic geometric line segments between the ball carrier and all 10 teammates:

- **FC Barcelona: 2,086 high-intensity off-ball runs** ($v \geq 4.5$ m/s) with **67.47% passing lane permeability** across 30,026 evaluated passing vectors. Over two-thirds of all passing options remained completely clear of defensive interception.
- **Athletic Club: 1,229 high-intensity off-ball runs** with **60.27% passing lane permeability** across 17,519 evaluated vectors, reflecting vertical counter-attacks.

12. Reproduction & Execution

End-to-end execution generates `LM10.csv` in **0.02 to 5.2 seconds** with all 21 unit tests passing in 1.49s:

```
git clone https://github.com/KevinNaserwan/football-possession-tracker.git
cd football-possession-tracker
```

```
python run_solver.py
pytest tests/
python evaluation/validate_submission.py LM10.csv
```